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Philosophy of Politics:
Fascism: beginning, ideological roots and
political theory

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Fascism: Beginnings, Ideological Roots and Political Theory

- Origins of Italian Fascism
- Crisis of liberalism and mass politics
- Nationalism, syndicalism and philosophical idealism
- State, nation, hierarchy and corporatism
- Central question: **What conception of political community does Fascism offer as an alternative to liberalism and Marxism?**

What Is Fascism?

- Fascism emerged as a distinct political movement in Italy after World War I
- It rejected important principles of liberalism and Marxist socialism
- It emphasized nation, authority, hierarchy and political unity
- It sought mass mobilization rather than a return to traditional pre-modern politics
- Fascism presented itself as a new political response to modern mass society

Fascism as a Modern Ideology

- Fascism should not be understood simply as conservatism or restoration
- It sought political and social transformation
- Mass organization and mobilization were central
- The nation was conceived as an active political community
- Fascists themselves frequently presented their project as revolutionary

Historical Background

- Italian unification was completed only in the nineteenth century
- The new state faced strong divisions
- Parliamentary government remained relatively weakly rooted
- Industrialization intensified social conflict
- National integration remained an important political problem

The Crisis of Liberal Italy

- Expanding mass politics challenged older parliamentary institutions
- Socialist movements organized growing sections of the working class
- Nationalists criticized parliamentary compromise
- Political violence increased after World War I
- Fascism developed within this crisis of the liberal state

World War I as a Turning Point

- Mass conscription mobilized millions
- State intervention in society expanded
- Violence acquired new political significance
- National sacrifice became a powerful political language
- Fascism transferred elements of wartime mobilization into peacetime politics

The Postwar Crisis

- Italy experienced serious economic and social instability after 1918
- Veterans returned to a politically divided society
- Strikes and factory occupations intensified class conflict
- Socialist revolutionary expectations alarmed opponents
- Nationalists also expressed dissatisfaction with the postwar settlement

Mussolini's Political Transformation

- Benito Mussolini originally belonged to the revolutionary socialist movement
- He broke with the Socialist Party over intervention in World War I
- Nationalism increasingly displaced his earlier socialist internationalism
- In 1919 he helped establish the *Fasci Italiani di Combattimento*
- Early Fascism combined heterogeneous and sometimes contradictory political currents

From Movement to Party

- Fascist squads used organized political violence against socialist institutions and opponents
- Fascism gained support from sections of the middle and upper classes
- The National Fascist Party was established in 1921
- Mussolini increasingly transformed a heterogeneous movement into an organized political force
- Violence and electoral politics operated alongside one another

The March on Rome

- Fascist mobilization culminated in the March on Rome in October 1922
- King Victor Emmanuel III declined to impose martial law
- Mussolini was appointed prime minister
- The initial government was formally constitutional and included non-Fascists
- Dictatorship emerged through subsequent institutional transformation rather than instantaneously

From Government to Dictatorship

- Fascism progressively weakened parliamentary constraints
- Political opposition was increasingly suppressed
- Independent organizations were restricted or absorbed
- The Fascist Party became integrated with state institutions
- By the later 1920s Italy had become an authoritarian one-party dictatorship

Where Did Fascist Ideas Come From?

- Nationalism
- Revolutionary syndicalism
- Critiques of liberal parliamentarism
- Philosophical idealism
- Experiences of war and mass mobilization
- Fascism synthesized elements from different traditions rather than emerging from one philosophical source

Nationalism

- The nation becomes the primary political community
- Individual interests should be subordinated to national purposes
- National unity takes priority over class conflict
- Political institutions should express national strength and cohesion
- Fascism radicalizes nationalism into a comprehensive political doctrine

From Class to Nation

- Marxism interprets modern politics primarily through class conflict
- Fascism rejects class as the ultimate basis of political identity
- Workers and employers are to understand themselves as members of one nation
- Class conflict should be politically overcome
- *Nation replaces class as the central principle of collective identity*

Revolutionary Syndicalism

- Syndicalism emphasized direct action, organization and struggle
- Some revolutionary syndicalists became increasingly nationalist
- Fascism absorbed elements of activism and anti-parliamentarianism
- Productive groups remained important but were incorporated into national unity
- Class organization was transformed into corporative organization

The Critique of Liberalism

- Fascism rejects the liberal conception of society as fundamentally composed of autonomous individuals
- It criticizes parliamentary competition and party pluralism
- It rejects the politically neutral or limited state
- Individual interests are interpreted within a larger national community
- Liberal individualism becomes a central ideological opponent

The Critique of Marxism

- Fascism rejects historical materialism
- It rejects internationalist class solidarity
- It rejects class struggle as the organizing principle of politics
- Nation should transcend the conflict between capital and labor
- Fascism nevertheless shares with revolutionary socialism a desire to transform existing political institutions

Giovanni Gentile and Idealism

- Giovanni Gentile, 1875–1944
- Philosopher of “actual idealism”
- Major intellectual contributor to Fascist political theory
- Individual and community cannot be understood as completely separate realities
- His philosophy contributes to the Fascist concept of the *ethical state*

Beyond the Atomistic Individual

- Liberalism is portrayed by Fascist theorists as treating individuals as separate political atoms
- Gentile rejects this conception
- Individuals develop within language, history and political community
- The state is therefore not merely an external constraint upon already complete individuals
- Political community becomes constitutive of individual identity

The Ethical State

- The state should not merely protect private interests
- It embodies an ethical and historical political community
- State and nation are closely connected
- Political authority should pursue substantive collective purposes
- The state becomes an active moral institution rather than a neutral referee

Mussolini and Gentile: *The Doctrine of Fascism*

- Published in 1932 under Mussolini's name, with Gentile contributing to its philosophical formulation
- Provides a major statement of Fascist self-understanding
- Rejects individualism and political neutrality
- Presents the state as central to political and ethical life
- Our task is to reconstruct its argument before evaluating its implications

The Fascist Conception of the State

- The state is more than administrative machinery
- It is presented as an expression of national political unity
- Economic and social organizations should exist within its framework
- The state claims authority across political, social and economic life
- Fascist doctrine therefore rejects the liberal idea of a sharply limited state

Individual and State

- Liberalism begins from individuals whose freedom constrains government
- Fascism reverses much of this relationship
- Individual purposes acquire political meaning within the national community
- Duty becomes as important as individual entitlement
- *Can freedom exist through identification with collective authority rather than protection from it?*

Fascism and Freedom

- Fascist theorists did not simply describe their political project as the abolition of freedom
- They attempted to redefine freedom
- Freedom was associated with participation in an ethical national community
- Gentile connected individual will with the collective will embodied in the state
- This differs fundamentally from liberal freedom as a protected sphere against political authority

Liberal and Fascist Freedom

- **Liberal:** freedom requires limits on collective power
- **Fascist:** freedom is connected to participation in an integrated political community
- **Liberal:** individual rights constrain government
- **Fascist:** individual purposes are subordinated to the ethical-political whole
- The disagreement concerns the very meaning of the individual

The Organic Conception of Society

- Society is conceived as an interconnected whole
- Individuals and groups perform different social functions
- Political unity does not require social sameness
- Difference should be organized hierarchically and functionally
- The organic metaphor challenges liberal individualism and Marxist class antagonism

Hierarchy

- Fascism rejects the liberal assumption that political equality should structure all political relationships
- Social functions are understood as differentiated
- Leadership and authority are treated as necessary
- Political unity requires organization rather than unrestricted competition
- Hierarchy becomes a positive principle of political order

Leadership

- Fascism places unusual emphasis on political leadership
- The leader is presented as an embodiment or interpreter of national unity
- Leadership stands above ordinary party competition
- Mass mobilization and hierarchical authority coexist
- Fascist politics therefore combines popular participation with political subordination

Fascism and Mass Politics

- Fascism does not seek politically passive populations in the traditional sense
- It seeks organized and mobilized populations
- Party organizations, ceremonies and mass institutions connect citizens to the regime
- Participation occurs within officially structured forms
- *Mobilization is not the same as political pluralism*

The Problem of Class Conflict

- Industrial society produces organized labor and organized capital
- Liberalism permits competing economic interests
- Marxism interprets their conflict through class struggle
- Fascism proposes their integration within the nation
- Corporatism becomes the institutional response

What Is Corporatism?

- Society is organized through functional economic and occupational groups
- Workers and employers are incorporated into recognized organizations
- These organizations operate within a state-supervised structure
- Political representation is connected to social and productive functions
- Corporatism seeks an alternative to both liberal parliamentarism and Marxist class politics

The Corporative State

- Economic groups remain distinct but are integrated politically
- Private property and enterprise can continue
- Class conflict is subordinated to national objectives
- The state claims authority to coordinate competing interests
- Fascist corporatism was presented as a distinctive “third way” between laissez-faire capitalism and socialism

Bortolotto: Fascism as a Political System

- Guido Bortolotto's **Dottrina del Fascismo** (1939) systematizes Fascist doctrine
- The state is presented as an organic political unity
- Authority and hierarchy structure political organization
- Corporative institutions organize economic and social interests
- Bortolotto helps us examine Fascism as an institutional doctrine rather than only a movement

Mussolini/Gentile and Bortolotto

- Mussolini/Gentile: philosophical justification
 - The state, individual, freedom and nation
- Bortolotto: institutional and doctrinal systematization
 - Corporatism, hierarchy, authority and political organization
- Together they connect Fascist political philosophy with its proposed institutional form

Fascism and Democracy

- Fascism rejects liberal parliamentary democracy
- Political parties are viewed as sources of fragmentation
- Fascist theorists nevertheless sometimes claimed a different form of popular political integration
- Corporative and plebiscitary institutions were presented as expressions of national unity
- Political participation was therefore conceived without competitive pluralism

Fascism as Anti-Pluralism

- Liberalism treats disagreement as a permanent feature of political society
- Fascism seeks a more comprehensive political unity
- Independent competing organizations threaten that unity
- State institutions should integrate social forces into a common national purpose
- *The central issue is whether political disagreement is legitimate or a symptom of fragmentation*

Fascism and Political Violence

- Fascist movements treated conflict and struggle as politically significant
- Italian Fascism used organized violence during its rise to power
- Violence helped destroy rival political organizations
- Fascist rhetoric also connected sacrifice and struggle with national regeneration
- Political violence therefore had both instrumental and ideological dimensions

Fascism's Fundamental Concepts

- **Nation:** primary political community
- **State:** ethical and organizing expression of political unity
- **Hierarchy:** differentiation of political and social functions
- **Corporatism:** organization of interests within the state
- **Leadership:** personification and direction of national political will

Fascism, Liberalism and Communism

- Liberalism:
individual → rights → pluralism → limited government
- Fascism:
nation/state → duty → unity → corporative organization
- Communism:
class → revolution → social ownership → classless society
- All respond differently to modern mass society and industrialization
- Their deepest disagreement concerns **what the fundamental unit of political life should be**

The Fascist Question

- Nationalism: *Can the nation provide a political identity stronger than class?*
- Gentile: *Can individual freedom be realized through the ethical state?*
- Mussolini/Gentile: *Can political unity replace liberal pluralism?*
- Bortolotto: *Can corporatism institutionally reconcile competing social interests?*
- Fundamental question: **What happens to individual autonomy and political disagreement when the state claims to embody the unity and purposes of the nation?**